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Bill Allred

Bill Allred has enjoyed an active career as a jazz trombonist and band leader. He was a staff musician during the early years of Walt Disney World in Orlando, and became a popular player at jazz parties across the country. He currently leads the Bill Allred Classic Jazz Band, and enjoys observing the career of his son, trombonist John Allred.

Bill was interviewed in Orlando, Florida on February 24, 2017 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Orlando, Florida. I'm pleased to have Bill Allred with me, trombonist and band leader and world traveler.

BA: Done a little bit of everything.

MR: Yeah. Well I want to congratulate you on — last I read your band has been together for 25 plus years.

BA: Yeah. We started in 1990, kind of a strange way we fabricated that group you know. Most of us were performing at a music hall called Rosie O'Grady's, which was in downtown Orlando in the Church Street Station area. And it was a music hall but yet the guy that ran it, who is still around, Bob Snow, had a band there. We had two principal singers, we had dancers, and we had a 7-, sometimes 8-piece band every night of the week you know.

MR: Every night of the week.

BA: And it lasted for 20 some years. I wasn't there — I opened it in '74, put the band together with some guys that I knew in town and some guys that both worked at Disney as well. And some of us stayed on for a while, stayed working at Disney days and continued working nights at this Rosie O'Grady's club, just to see if it would catch on. And of course it was an unbelievable success from day one, you know, I mean packed. Lines around the block you know.

MR: What kind of music?

BA: We were playing Dixieland and some swing. Maybe an occasional pop tune. Not much though. And my thing was it's got to be good, you know. If it's just a funny hat band, I don't know, I'd rather have a good band and do the show biz stuff. That was my philosophy.

MR: You'd rather have a good band than do the show biz stuff?

BA: Well no.

MR: Or both?

BA: Both, but we found that we could salute this and salute that and do the songs and do the Sophie Tucker stuff, whatever, Dixieland, and still put out a quality product. And we got a lot of applause for that.

MR: I've often had a hard time describing to someone, or to my own self, the difference, if there is any, between Dixieland and trad and Chicago and classic.

BA: You know it's so complicated. I mean here I've played it for 50 some years. But it's pretty much the same. Now the trad people, and I do the quotes, I mean they want to dwell really early on back to the early days of the New Orleans jazz. And Dixieland could encompass anything from the Dukes of Dixieland and Al Hirt and Pete Fountain, that sort of thing. I mean they stuck to their guns as far as the literature is concerned, as far as the tunes, except Al Hirt, he kind of branched out to the pop thing with all his little pop things, and they were tremendously successful. But I got weaned on Dixieland — when I was in high school we had a — I was just looking at the picture of it the other day, I can't believe it — but we had a band consisting of tuba, accordion, trumpet and trombone. And a really, not really a jazz aficionado as far as the tuba player, but he was a good basic player. And the accordion player could play banjo as well. And we played at the basketball games in Rock Island, Illinois, in the '50 '1, '2, '3 I guess. And we played the fight songs and that, but we also played as much trad or Dixieland as we could get by with. And the band was pretty decent. And I still — just three of the guys out of our four are still around: me and Bob and Jim. So I got started on that right away.

MR: Didn't your father play on steamboats?

BA: My dad worked on the early versions of some of the steamboats, I think some early Streckfus stuff, but this had to be 1920. And unfortunately and sadly, my dad died when I was like eight years old you know. He never heard me play, never heard my son play, which if I have any regrets in my life that's one of them. My mother died when I was eleven, but my sister was 20 years older than me, so she kind of gathered up some of my dad's lore as far as the river. And he was just a punk kid but he was playing piano and he also played banjo and guitar because in his estimation, or in his words, the pianos were so bad on these boats that you really didn't know what you were going to get. I mean he hopped from boat to boat and ended up having a sibling, a younger brother that I had never met and never been able to find, so that kept him out of the war, and he gravitated to Rock Island, Illinois, where there was, then, there was some music stuff going on with steamboats going across the river. So he gravitated there and met my mom, then I was born and so on and so forth. But I never really got to work with him, you know it's sad.

MR: It's in your genes and you passed it on obviously.

BA: So it was in me and I had a couple of uncles who used to play, one played guitar and one played piano, and they would jam at the house once in a while. And I started out on clarinet, pretty, really bad player.

MR: Did you have a metal one?

BA: Yes. I had a metal one that came apart which a couple of people said boy you should have saved that. But anyway, I took it back to the rental place and got a trombone because I heard that Tommy Dorsey and I shared the same birthday, November 19. The total reason for that. And I saw it in *Photoplay* magazine.

MR: What's it called?

BA: *Photoplay*.

MR: Oh *Photoplay*. Okay.

BA: They had a big thing about Tommy Dorsey, oh my God November 19th. So back goes the clarinet.

MR: I love that because that's the first I'd heard of people talk about — well why'd you go to that instrument. And well I found it behind the couch or whatever. But that's a first.

BA: And I really took to it. Because I hadn't even started seventh grade yet was when our band program started. There was no sixth grade music back in 1940 something. And so I was playing "Jam On Home" you know which was bad for me because for me reading music came second or something I had to learn to do. I recall when I left Rock Island to — what I did, I had a chance to go out to Vegas a few times and I got to know Charlie Teagarden. At that time he was the secretary of the union in Las Vegas, but played in a lot of clubs and stuff like that. And his words to me, I'll never forget this, I said, "Someday I want to have my own band and play all this Dixie stuff, but maybe play it with a little more complica — you know, do it with some charts and stuff like —." They said, "Well you've got to get your ass out of Rock Island, first of all." That's a quote. Which later it came to pass and so anyway there's all this talk about the new thing that's going to be happening in Orlando. And Charlie Teagarden knew about it, a lot of the musicians that I knew in Rock Island and Davenport, that area, said boy you ought to look into that. So I just clipped a coupon from the union newspaper and I belonged to the union then. I sent a letter off and they said yes if you'd like to audition we're having auditions at the — I forget which hotel it was — in Miami. So I lived in Rock Island. So I mustered up the money, and I was married then. I flew from Rock Island to Chicago to Miami, and they had an audition set up at a hotel down there. And they had two things. They had a big band set up with a couple of Disney music people from Anaheim of course. And they had a combo room, which is where I excelled. I mean I had been working on my reading purposely and so I did okay in the big band thing. I got through

Miami who was like the heavy piano player in Miami, a guy named Jack Keller. K-E-L-L-E-R. What a great piano player. On drums Ray McKinley. On bass Chubby Jackson. And I'm saying to myself holy shit, I mean like wow. I mean I played in the Navy band you know, so — when I was in the Navy from '54 to '57, so I met a few people but never got a chance to work with them. And so I played about an hour in the combo room. They said, "Do some more." You know. And they'd invite this guy in. Sonny Anderson was a big Disney Entertainment guy then. And Jim Christenson ended up being the first band leader out here. And they liked what I did. And I was businessman enough to follow up with a letter saying boy, you know, I really enjoyed that and I said, I can see myself really fitting in. So I did get a letter back saying we really were impressed with what you did and our play would be to put you in the big marching band, which we intend to break up into smaller bands, a polka band, a sax quartet, a town band and a Dixieland band. And he said we of course like what you do as far as the Dixieland, and so that's how I got on Disney. Well Disney didn't move you or pay for your move, I mean we had to get there. So I had to sell a house and move two kids and a wife down to Orlando. Maybe this is too much Disney stuff.

MR: No, what did your family think about the whole thing?

BA: Mixed feelings. At the present time up in Illinois, see I had gotten out of the Navy and my music background in the Navy really didn't do me a hell of a lot of good. I mean I was jobbing around the area which is, nothing going on. Dances and playing at the Elks and a couple of clubs that were decent. But yeah, there was, and it later cost me a wife. And bless her heart, she got thrust into the entertainment business which I don't think she was quite ready for. But anyway the kids loved it. I mean my daughter ended up working at Disney selling balloons. My son got on the music staff pretty much as soon as he could graduate from high school. So that was good. And we had the 20-piece big band and we could play anything. We went back to shows, we played all the Disney stuff, all the movie music, with a 20-piece group you can do that. You've got eight reeds. So that was good. The nice thing about it, we had such a wide variety of stuff that you did. Well this is really interesting, probably more about Disney —

MR: No go ahead. I wonder, you were playing music that nowadays they're just piping in. Is that a fair statement?

BA: What's that now?

MR: Well back in those days you were playing live music for all these things, and I would guess that nowadays much of that music is just prerecorded and played.

BA: Yeah. We did live concerts — the thing that I really enjoyed, we did live concerts in Town Square, set up in the Square. And the nice thing about it is Jim Christenson, the

played a lot of that. We had a lot of guest conductors, guys that wrote some of these marches that I'd never even met them. And of course Meredith Wilson was there for the grand opening for Disney. You know, he was the — and he hung out in the band room. He loved everything. I mean what a great guy. And so that was — and here I am from Rock Island, Illinois. I hadn't met anybody. And looking back I mean my move from Rock Island to Orlando was the best career move I could have ever made anywhere. I mean I met everybody in the world. And the guy that put me on the map was Dean Kincaid. Famous sax player. Of course you know that. And they had, when Disney opened they had, on the top of the Contemporary Hotel, they had a place called the show at the top or something like that. And they had a 12-piece band playing for dancing, but also backing shows and a fine place to eat. So you could go there, I mean people from town could go there and have dinner, a nice dinner and dance a little bit, see The Four Freshmen, Mel Torme, Trini Lopez, people like that, semi-names, but that's not fair to say I guess. But God I loved the Freshmen, one of my favorite groups of all time. But occasionally they would need a third trombone, they only had two in the band. So I made it known that I'd be interested. So I got an occasional call to go up there and play. Well Dean Kincaid was the baritone sax player. And it's funny because Disney had also hired him to write some Dixieland lead sheets for some of these musicians who weren't that familiar with trad music. And Dean Kincaid said yeah, he said, "I've got to get back" — So one night we were having a drink and he said, "Yeah I've got to get back to my hotel," he says, "they've got me doing a bunch of these Dixieland 101 things."

MR: Dixieland 101.

BA: But anyway Dean Kincaid said to me, he said, "Man, I like the way you play." And I was 32 years old and hot to trot, you know, doing it all. A great fan of Abe Lincoln. That was my boy you know. The west coast, Abram Lincoln.

MR: I'm not familiar with him I'm sorry to say.

BA: Oh what an unbelievable player. But anyway he said, "I like the way you play," he said, "you know" he says, "I go to this Manassas Jazz Festival up by Washington, DC" and he said, "God all the musicians, I think I could get you on that." I said, "Well I don't have any cred to help you." And he said, "No yeah I can do it." So by God he got me on that festival. And I met Wild Bill Davison, who I later toured with, Lou McGarrity, Cutty Cutshall, Eddie Con — I mean all the guys. And I got to play with them. I mean Jesus I got —

MR: Pinch me, right? I can't believe this, alongside with those people.

BA: I know. I mean you know so I told Dean, when he asked me, and if anybody asks me, I'd played like the Mississippi Jazz Festival or something back home, but nobody there. So I

friends with for years. But I'm thinking God dang this is unbelievable. And it was. I mean Lou McGarrity. And I met Wallace Davenport, a black trumpeter who was pretty hot in New Orleans, and ended up doing two albums with him and would go down to New Orleans and sit in with him. You know I couldn't sign on because he was on a small club group. But that was the biggest door that anybody had ever opened for me. Well later on Dean was sick and he was in the hospital here in Orlando. And he was terminal, the word was. And I went up to the hospital hat in hand and I said, "Dean, man, I'm sorry you are ill." I said, "But I've got to tell you, you put me on the map, you made it for me." He said, "Awww you would have done it by yourself." I said, "No you're wrong. I wouldn't have. I could never have gone anywhere and met the volume of people." And I said, "Jesus." And then later on, the first thing Wild Bill Davison ever said to me, he was getting ready to do a set. And they had me scheduled with some sets. And I went up to him and I said, "Wild Bill" I said, "I've kind of been a fan of yours forever" you know, "I love what you do and then the Condon thing." And I said, "Can I do a set with you sometime." And of course Wild Bill of course, the old bastard, he said "You want to play with me" he said, "I've got a set coming up" he said, "get your ass up on the bandstand and let's have some fun." So I gave it my best shot and later he hired me for all kinds of stuff overseas.

MR: What do you do in that situation, or maybe later, if you got on the bandstand and someone calls a tune and everybody knows it but you?

BA: I have several albums from the Manassas Jazz Festival that I recorded and it's me learning songs. I mean honest to God. Oh you're so right. Because I was there and a guy, I forget the guy's name. He led a band called the Red Onion Jazz Band, and he came up to me and he says, "Hey, Allred" he says, "our trombone player's late getting in, can you do a couple of sets with us." I said, "Yeah." And so they're calling all these tunes, and I knew some, mostly I didn't. And boy my ears were just like this big and I'm giving it my best shot.

MR: Who are you listening to mostly?

BA: You know I started listening to one guy called Miff Mole, was an early trombone player, Bill Rank, early Bix. And people like that. And then eventually as I got a little older, especially as I got into the Navy and guys were listening to Watrous and Carl Fontana and people, I later worked with all of them. And I started — but I'm proud to say I really had the roots. I got criticized a little for maybe playing a little too modern in that genre. But you don't know what to do.

MR: I was going to ask you about that. Because the list people that you've played with, if you go from Dizzy Gillespie to Al Hirt, do you try to tailor your playing to better match with

BA: I think you do. I really think you do. And thank God I had enough technical ability to be able to do that. And I guess that's not really bragging I mean it's just — you know I remember Turk Murphy, I sat in with Turk's band out in San Francisco. I loved that band. I just — there was a romance about that whole San Francisco thing that I really liked it. And I was playing and got done, and we're down in Turk's break room where everybody's filling up their pipes with all this magic stuff. And I never really got into that much. But Turk said, "Hey, I like the way you play, kid" he said, "you play too damn many notes though." I said, I got a quote out of Turk. And it was a fault of mine. I wanted to play a good chorus and so maybe I was doing a little too much. Wild Bill loved it.

MR: Our benefactor, who started this project, was a frequent attender at these jazz parties. And I recall he would say something like, he's look at the list of musicians and go, "Oh yeah I like him, oh Watrous well too many notes." He would say that kind of thing. And I know that certain players would sort of temper their approach when they looked out at the audience and assess what they see.

BA: You know, and I think the ability of a player to stylize like that, I think is important. I mean I do jazz parties now, a variety of them. There's one thing I do, the party that's like a cruise off of Lauderdale. And the people that go on that thing, they want to hear the Dixieland stuff. They don't care if you get a little erratic in your choruses but you do, by virtue of that, you kind of control your torrents of notes. But still then you're going — it's not only the complexity of what you play, it is the, it's the tunes and the way you — you know like I'm getting ready to go to a party out in Colorado Springs that I've done quite a few times. And you know you've got to bone up, you've got to do some Latin tunes, you've got to sound like you know what you're doing. And my son had the same problem you know. You have to stylize. But you don't want to overdo it because they it sounds foreign, then it sounds like what the hell's he doing.

MR: Yeah. You're playing down to people.

BA: Yeah. And that's not fair.

MR: Yeah that's a really interesting phenomenon, the jazz parties. I wonder if you see, are the audiences maintaining themselves?

BA: Pretty good. Pretty good. It's the aging audience is a problem that I don't think any of us know quite how to deal with it. I mean we all would love to get all the kids involved but we know it's probably not going to happen maybe in our lifetime. And you go places and here's an example. I think we played down in Vero Beach with my 8-piece group you know. My 8-piece band, we'll start from playing "The Chant" and go all the way up to playing "Love for Sale" by Buddy Rich. Stuff like that. Try to expand their horizons a little bit. But they had an all-star kids band there and we were going to follow them as the

MR: I know. “Wait, there’s something for you here to listen to.”

BA: I’m thinking what! And we had a few choice words to say. But it’s a sad thing. But the jazz party group is elderly, because jazz parties by virtue of the people they have to bring in, it’s very expensive.

MR: Why is it that there seems to be very few African American people in the audience, and sometimes on the bandstand, depending on the style of music.

BA: Yeah. And there are a few. I guess it’s the Uncle Tom thing. A lot of them just associate that music with the old days when Teddy Wilson couldn’t find a hotel because he was black or something like that. And I don’t know who’s — I guess family-wise and friend-wise they’re cultivating that. They’re keeping that going faster than we’re getting them to play in parties and groups you know. I had a call — in my career in Orlando, which is kind of waning, I mean there’s not much going on, you know I used to book some things and people would call me up and say, “Yeah I need this group.” The guy wanted a black Dixieland band for this party. I said, “We don’t have anyone.” I mean there’s a band with a couple of black guys in it. Like in my 8-piece band I have a trumpet player who’s mother’s black and his dad’s Hispanic. That’s as close as we can come. But there are, the people like the black trumpet players, there’s three or four of them, they all did the Louis time on the shows and then the black trombone player — my son even recorded an album with.

MR: Oh Wycliffe Gordon.

BA: Wycliffe. So there are those. And I remember I was with Wild Bill Davison’s, I mean I never played with so many hotshot musicians in my life as the old Norway ship jazz parties with Hank and Shelly used to book the musicians.

MR: O’Neil.

BA: Yeah Hank O’Neil out of New York. And we were playing this session, they wanted a jam session so we had Dizzy Gillespie and I forget he was a reed player, the tall younger guy, great, great player, Doc Cheatham, you know, who was better than a lot of people gave him credit for. I tuned in Johnny Carson or somebody one night and he’s sitting in with the band. And Dizzy was great. And we were just — but it seemed like there were more black players left over from the big band era. And I had a festival — several festival directors in Europe say, “We have no drawing cards — the Dizzies and the —”

MR: Milt Hintons, they’re all gone now.

BA: But there are some around but it’s so difficult to get them interested. I think the schools that promote jazz I know I’ve done a couple of things with UCF —
[phone ringing]
appearing with their band

MR: Years ago I attended the International Association of Jazz Educators, big huge organization, and thousands of people come to these events. And they had a panel discussion that said "Trad Jazz is Alive and Well." Well the people on the panel didn't really believe it I think, and not only that, with all the performances during the weekend there was no trad jazz. And I personally think it's because the music is — most of the time — very upbeat and happy and thus it doesn't — it's not looked on as a real art form. It's too darn happy. And that's just my own personal feeling about it.

BA: No I can see where you — now there's this other whole avenue of like the New Orleans guys, the Onward Brass Band and this, where they combine blues, rock & roll, trad, and marching around, and kind of carrying the banner of New Orleans, and that's good. I had a narrow escape one time because this girl said, "Oh do you guys play New Orleans jazz?" I said, "Yeah." You know. And she said, "Well we'd like you to play our wedding. Right after we get married we want to march down the street or something, to this hotel." And we come up with a price, they had money to spend. She said, "I'll send you a tape of some of the stuff I like." And it was all this very Onward Brass Band Stuff and we managed to learn a couple of things. So that's another whole different thing. But at least it's doing it.

MR: Yeah. You led me to a question about being a band leader. And there's a couple of things I want to ask you. First of all, what requirements, what do you require of a musician in order to hire them to be in your band.

BA: Well I mean the band that I put together, which started pretty much as the Rosie O'Grady's band, then the guy that owned the place sold it and you could see that it was kind of going, where in 1990 a bunch of us left there and we still had a couple of festivals that we'd been invited to, so we just kept that going and then — so I came up with this band. I really liked what Billy Maxted did, Matty Matlock and then Bob Crosby's Bobcats that in other words they read music but they also played jazz you know. So I had to get somebody that could read pretty well. Not symphony, standards, but could also improvise. And that's what we were selling for a long time. And I got hell for it. This is the stupidest thing. But we were playing down in — I don't want to fill up with a bunch of junk, but we were playing down in South Florida somewhere with a bunch of local guys, no music, it was a jam thing, a good jazz group. And so we got down to the gig and I'm stepping down off the stage and this lady came up and got right in my face and she said, "See how good you can play without your sheet music?" Probably she didn't like —

MR: She didn't want to see music stands on the stage.

BA: No. She thought that was stupid you know. And there are people to this day that if you are reading music that's not jazz. And I mean if that's all you do, if nobody ever solos,

And that's what we did. And we did it for 26 years. And it seemed to work for us. But there were those that thought just give me guys that are going to play you know.

MR: What would cause you to give someone the pink slip?

BA: Well there was one guy who — really into drugs. I saw so many guys pretty much get ruined by getting too much into drugs or getting too — there was a trombone player, I won't mention his name, who was a real entrepreneur. I mean he sold drugs and he was very busy. And guys were coming to him to make a connection or something. So it was interfering with — he wasn't concentrating on the music. That was one. And you've got to be in tune with the guys in the band you know. I mean I had an 8-piece group, and everybody had to pretty much understand what we were to accomplish you know. A couple of guys had other stuff going and you could tell they weren't really interested, and so that to me was a — I mean we still are friends and everything but I said, "Go do your thing, but I've got to concentrate on this little circle of stuff here." So it's a function of concentration or where you put all of your effort. And there are other people that you just don't get along with them.

MR: Yeah. There's a chemistry to maintain with a number of people like that.

BA: Yeah and there are guys that are just bastards. There was a drummer that played too loud. And you say something to him and people are very, very, very particular about how they play. And you've got to be really careful. Like don't say, too many notes, or not enough notes, or the guy isn't reading the charts. There was one, a drummer that, I mean he could read but he had to get the arrangements. We were doing some stuff by Louie Bellson and that. And that's pretty heavy drum stuff. And I said, "Look, just spend a little time with it. I do it." I said, "I'm not this hotshot at reading, I'm probably the worst reader in the damn band." But if we get a new tune and I need to spend some time with it or concentrate, I do it. So there's different things that would cause you to —

MR: Right. What's the first question that you ask when someone calls with an inquiry about your band?

BA: I usually ask them what do you want this music for. What do you want to accomplish. Is it a reunion, is it a wedding, which right away gives you a whole roomful of different people. So I said we're going to have to play some swing, we're going to have to play a little rock, which we never did. We usually would just play for the swing people. But yeah, you find out what they want, what kind of music they want. Then it naturally gravitates to how much you got to spend, or they ask you what you would charge them.

MR: Yeah. That's always the tough part for me.

BA: Well I had a thing happen and I've got to tell you this. A guy called me from Daytona and he said, "Bill Allred, I understand you have a swing band." And I said, "Yeah, we

our 25th. She wants a swing band, so give me a price for your group." And it was Daytona, it was a hotel, and I was trying to be fair, because we need to reach out a little bit in some of the different areas. So I gave him a fair price. So about a week later this same guy calls me, I forget his name, he said, "Bill Allred?" I said, "Yeah." He said, "I'm the guy that called about the swing band." I said, "Oh yeah." He said, "I want to talk to you about your price." So I'm thinking right away oh yeah, here we go you know, do you really need the bass player. And you get that.

MR: Do you really need the bass player!

BA: Yeah I've gotten that question. Well he said, "How many in that band?" I said, "There's eight of us." He said no, no, no. He said I want a band like Lawrence Welk. He says, "I want all the saxophones." He said, "I want the same instrumentation. I want all the horns," he said, "but I want a guy singer and a girl singer and I gotta have a guitar player." And I'm doing some mental stuff. And he gets done with all that and I said, "Well Johnny" Johnny was his — "Johnny I said, the price I gave you was for eight guys, I said I'm going to have to re-do that and it's going to be a lot higher." He said, "Well figure it out and let me know because that's what I know she would love." You know. So I'm figuring it out and it's getting up into many thousands. Sound man, because you get that many people then you've got to get a sound guy, we had to bring our own sound and stuff like that, and the book, and so he calls back a couple of days later and I gave him the price and he said, "Hmm," he said, "that's" and he reiterates, he said, "now it's two singers, right." I said, "I've got a really good gal and good guy from Disney, sings great, does all the crooner stuff." Oh that's great. And guitar player. I said it's got a killer band. And I didn't stick it to him, we gave everybody a fair wage and he said, "Let's do it." I couldn't believe it. And we went over there and played great, they loved it, there were people coming in from other parties you know. That was a big band. And it was just amazing. He paid us, and he had dinner for everybody. And five years later they did the same thing again. And that's the end, I've lost track. That was the total thing in reverse. Usually boy it's a lot. Well Disney's famous thing, Disney always wants to book a trio for everything.

MR: That's a good story. I've had occasion where I'll give a price for a trio and then I'll kick myself because the person will go, "Is that per man?" And that's not what I meant, but well yes. It's a little too late to do that.

BA: Oh yeah. And you know you get some really fair people and then — and we were lucky enough in my band to find an angel, and this guy, his name was Max Corzilius. Max, when he worked at Dupont he figured out a way to effectively filter jet fuel. He explained it to me one time. But he had the presence of mind at a certain point when he got a little

this filtered jet fuel, so he became immensely rich, oh my God. So he heard us one time and he said, "Boy I love your band," he said, "do you guys ever play out here at Smithsonian?" I said, "No, no." He got us booked at the Smithsonian for their Friday jazz things. And got us booked all over the east coast, Baltimore and a little place called Rock Hall where they had a jazz club. And when we started playing the jazz festival in Clearwater — we're not there this year but I mean every, for a long time we played it. And Max, he went to the Clearwater people and he says, "Tell you what," he said, "you need sponsors, right?" They said yes. Usually they're hunting them. He said, "Well I'll give you twenty thousand dollars" but he said, "half has to go to the Bill Allred band. So we got a huge raise that lasted for five or six years. So we want to do something for him because he's kind of a hack drummer. I mean he's not a good drummer but he could keep time you know. So I called him up I said, "Max" I said, "we're doing an album." And I said, "Would you like to play on a couple of tracks?" And I'm sure he said, "Yes!" But he said, "I don't know." I said, "Max, you'll be fine." I said, "Warren, our drummer, will be right there with you." So we recorded it, he's on two tracks, did a good job, just kept time, that's all we wanted you know. And I sent him a paycheck for recording scale for what he did which then was like $320 or something like that. And strictly above board you know. And he was so thrilled I guess his wife said he framed it and put it in his den, the check. Because I wondered why it never cleared. So I opened the mail one day and I get a check for twelve thousand dollars from him. And I called him and I said, "Max, it's got to be a mistake here." He said, "No, no. I understand you guys record these albums and make no money until you pay off the production." That's what we did. And we were traveling enough then that we'd get things paid off quickly. And he said, "This will help you pay off your album." I said it's about three quarters. And he wouldn't take it back. But he died on us about seven years ago, and that was a big loss, and not being too monetarily oriented but —

MR: Yeah, that's an angel for sure.

BA: But anyway he was great, neat guy, and his wife, she died as well a few years later. But they're out there.

MR: I want to play name this trombone player.

[audio interlude]

BA: Playing a lot of my licks.

MR: Okay well that makes sense because that's you.

BA: Oh McPartland. Oh my God. And then I was so careful because I said you can't do too much.

MR: I like it. That comes from our library.

MR: I do.

BA: Herman Foretich, his nickname was "Dirty Shirt" it seemed like he never changed his shirt. But Spider Ridgeway was a good drummer. I mean he knew how to play trad. He could lay it on you and just make you play, you know, one of those drummers. And he was also a hopeless drunk. I mean he'd get started drinking and he's gone for the weekend. So we were getting ready to go on this tour which — I don't have this either , one of these days I've got to get it. But I think I've got a tape somewhere. Wow. Billy Allred.

MR: Yeah.

BA: Of Las Vegas. But anyway, so Jimmy had heard Spider play and he knew he wanted that sound. So he hired a guy from a local high school, a big barrel-chested PE teacher, and he assigned him to Spider Ridgeway. He said, "If he touches a drink kick his ass." I mean this guy stayed with him. And Spider would tell us, "Oh man I'd love to have a drink but this bastard won't —." That's the way he talked. And he had a spotless tour. Man he kicked that band all during the thing. We played and we ended up playing in Atlanta in the underground. And this guy kept him straight, and Jimmy paid him. Marian did a couple of tunes. God that was fun. Gene Mayl.

MR: You said, when you weren't sure who this was you said, "Well he's got some of my licks." So what are your licks? How do you recognize.

BA: It's hard to say, it's just little things that you do you know. Stuff that you heard or figured out. See there are guys that want to emulate a certain player. And I don't want to mention any names but there are guys that can play exactly like somebody else. And I told my son when he started, now he was really into taking Carl Fontana's things and —

MR: Transcribing them?

BA: Transcribing them and playing the licks. And I said, "Now John," I said, "there is" and I said, "I appreciate what you're doing, you're doing a lot of this that I couldn't do" you know," but I said, "you've got to play like you eventually. You've got to take all these licks that you've heard different guys do and all, especially on trombone, which has no keys, so you're really at the mercy of doing a lot of tricks with your lips, with the [scats] doodle tonguing and double tonguing and stuff like that. And I do all that stuff, or I used to. But anyway, you harvest all these and you mold them into the way you play. And I've said this at clinics and stuff. You know I said you don't want to say, "Boy listen to that guy, he sounds just like Lou McGarrity." I mean you can to an extent, but you want people to say that sounds just like Joe Smith. And I think my son has accomplish that, a little Carl, a little like the guy that got murdered —

MR: Oh yeah, I can't come up with his name, the west coast.

BA: Frank Rossolino. Frank did a lot of those lip things that some guys can't do. Some guys try. I can't do it. And so you take all these various elements and you mold them into the way you play. I think I've done that. But I was madly in love with Abe Lincoln. And Abram Lincoln was a trombone player from Ohio somewhere and ended up recording with Matty Matlock. I got involved with Matty Matlock heavily because I loved his book. This was arranged Dixieland. And I ended up buying most of his library from his son, who I met. The way it started, when we were working at Disney we played a couple of Matty Matlock's charts. We had this piano player who transcribed them for us. So I'm at the L.A. Classic Jazz Festival one weekend and we were up in the break area talking about this and that. And the guys says, "Well if you want to get some more of those arrangements," he said, "Matty's son is playing guitar down in the next room here." "Wow!" So I got to be good friends with Buddy Matlock, who later died way too young. He was out jogging, one of those you know. But he made it possible for me to purchase copies of the scores to Matty's stuff. At that particular time I was working with Disney and there were guys that worked in the Disney library copying all the music and wanted to make extra money so I hired them and got most of the book copied, which just recently this year I've sold it, the entire library, the copies that I had, back to a guy out on the west coast who is going to try to get them played you know. I played them all over the world. But anyway I love what Matty did. So Abe Lincoln was his trombone player. And this guy played with a fire and brimstone, and he had unbelievably high chops, I mean even Watrous — last year he said, "Man," he said, we were talking about Abe Lincoln and he said, "yeah," he said, "Abe owned high F." That's all there was to it.

MR: For Bill to say that, that's something.

BA: Oh my God yeah. Bill and I got along good. First time I ever met him I was scared to death.

MR: I know what you mean.

BA: They scheduled me and him to do a tune, two tunes together with a rhythm section at this Colorado Springs. And the guy that booked that was famous for that, putting you on the spot you know. Because he did that to me with Carl, with Watrous and — I never played with Rossolino — but anyway he did that so Watrous, he gets up on the stand and I said, "Bill, what a pleasure man, I've enjoyed your work for years." And he said, "Well I caught you on the last set," he said, "you sounded good." He said, "Let's play some music." Which is neat. And I had to say this, I looked over and I said, "Well, don't be too mean to me man or I'll get my kid after you." Because John at that point, he'd been on the road with Woody, you know, he was on his way up. And Watrous laughed his butt off. And we were great from then on.

MR: Do you guys ever — I can just picture this scenario where your son calls you up and says, "Hey guess what I'm doing?" And you say, "Oh yeah, well guess what I'm doing." Like one upsmanship.

BA: It is. There's a little bit of that. Like I sat in with Woody's band one time when they played at Disney here, and played a couple of tunes with them. But no John, I always — a favorite barb I always lay on the people, I say, "Yeah it's a special thing when you have a son that plays the same instrument as you." I said, "There's a defining moment in your life when your son looks at you and says, 'no dad, it goes like this.'" And I don't know if that actually happened like that but it did you know, and he'd help me with some of this. Because he took my advice. John, you know him and his mother and I had divorced and so he lived with his mom up in North Carolina until he graduated from high school. So then John moved down to Orlando with me and my new wife and I said, "Well what do you want to do?" I said, "If you want to go to college I'll be happy to help you as much as I can financially. If you want to go to the Navy I know most of the guys out at the base" because I'd played with the Navy unit band. I said, "What do you want to do?" He said, "I just want to play." I said, "Well that's easier said than done." So I took him out to Disney and had him, set up an audition with a rhythm section and my son. Two or three of the guys were there when I auditioned you know, down in Miami. So John played about three tunes, and Sonny Anderson and another guy said, he says, "We'll take him." We'll take him. I said, "What are you going to do." He said, "Well it just so happens that we have a young Dixieland-type show band at Disneyland in Anaheim that the trombone player is leaving to go back to school, and if John wants the gig it's his. John went from high school to work for Disney. And of course, and I always say this, he had a good job for about three years and pissed all the money away. He did buy a car, but he did hang around a lot of the rehearsal bands in LA, got to meet a lot of people, and he would go out and play these gigs, and I pushed him on. I said, "John, I don't care what kind of gig or how stupid it might seem to you, it's experience." And I stressed the reading man. I said, "John," I learned to read okay. I was never a great reader. But I said, "I pushed it aside because I started playing by ear so early in my career, before I was even in seventh grade, playing jam sessions." So I said, "That's paramount, man, you've got to read your ass off. Nothing that's going to baffle you." I says that will bring dividends because I can tell you've got a good ear, you can play jazz, and you couple that with being an excellent reader and I says you'll never be out of work. And I was right.

MR: Now he can do a Broadway show and —

BA: And he said, later on he said you know, he said, "I took your advice." He says, "When I first started with Woody" he said, "I got my ass kicked a little. But Woody liked what he

did and John, unfortunately, John was with Woody while Woody started to get sick and then died and then the thing kind of crumbled there.

MR: What's your opinion on going to school for jazz?

BA: Well I mean I wish I had. Maybe not for jazz. I wish I would have gone to school for composition. Because I have so many great ideas. I've dictated so many great ideas, as far as charts. And I say great ideas, not bragging. But I really feel that if I would have spent the time in Theory and stuff like that in school instead of down at some black club in Rock Island trying to learn how to play bebop lines and — but it all goes in your bag of tricks. But I just could have done better as far as my personal — but at least I passed that on to John along with some common sense. But he's a kid, all of a sudden he got a couple of good offers and then all of a sudden he got an offer that was a little better and he would drop that one and I said, "Hold it. You can't do that." I said, "You'll get a reputation so quick" you know, don't hire John Allred because if a better offer comes along he's going to dump your — you know. I said, "That's discipline." I said, "Cool it on the drugs. I know damn well you're going to have a little snort once in a while but boy, don't let it get out of control." And he was good in that regard. It never hurt him. And I said, "The business side of music is so important." I mean treat people well, you know, back up what you say you're going to do And then the Broadway thing, here's the thing, he's doing, right now they're in the preliminary rehearsals for "Hello Dolly." And Bette Midler and David Hyde Pierce — it's going to be a good show. And I think he's the only guy in the band that's ever seen the movie. So John does the research. And that's so good. I taught him all that shit. I said, "You've got to live it a little. You may run into some corny situations but bite your tongue and do it." You know, "Go to the Tonys." And he's so glad. He did it. But then, like you say, then you've got to put your butt on that seat and deliver. You've got to play it.

MR: Well that's some great advice, and you guys got to record together a couple of times?

BA: Yeah. He was on all these 13 albums we did with my band. We did a lot of stuff together, two trombones, and we would have done more with that, but you know I think John, and I'll give him credit, I think he was a little afraid of the dog and pony show idea of the father/son thing. And I don't fault him for that you know. Because he does these high echelon parties and going on with this group and that group. He was with Harry Connick for a while and was out with Woody and Rich Matteson was a great experience. He went to Japan with Rich and his tuba-euphonium group that he had. And so that's a good deal. And there are situations where a father and son will form this group and you know six times out of ten the son can't blow his nose. And it's sad. Now John, I can go out, we did a thing out in Topeka, Kansas for the jazz society and kicked their butt man, we did it.

what each other's going to do and so it comes out so rehearsed sounding when it isn't sometimes. Now we rehearse stuff, but, so I'm very proud of him. Like I say I'm very sad that my dad never heard me play or him. But I've been lucky. It seems like my big career push was kind of based around Disney and that, and as much as I bitch about Disney's music program pretty much being gutted, I mean it's pathetic, but I can't fault Disney. They put me on the map. I'll never forget that. I mean I came down here and every day I discover something. Oh my God, I've only read about this guy and he's coming to sit in with our band or coming to direct the band, and that Meredith Wilson thing and Rob McConnell was in town. Because Disney had a really active music program with the college students. And you asked — and I got sidetracked — I think music schools are great. I think it's sad because they're turning out droves and droves or wonderful players who either go back to school and train other kids, you know. I don't know what —

MR: — what they're going to do.

BA: Because there's no, there's no comp — there's no more downtown this and downtown that. Like at Rosie O'Grady's, when Rosie O'Grady's was running in downtown Orlando, and when Disney was cranking with all their bands and stuff, I mean the musical climate in this town was un-freaking-believable. I mean and I was doing some contracting then where I'd, we'd do orchestral things for Ray Charles and we did a dozen shows with Ray. But you could get on the phone and come up with a band. I've put together a 53-piece orchestra to back up the Moody Blues. And you can get them. They're in town. You know, 36 strings. And the first thing we ever did with them we had 36 strings and two percussionists and two bass viols, and a full woodwind section you know with oboes and English horns and flutes. And then the Moody Blues, who were great guys by the way, from England, we had a lot of common friends over there. Then a sweetener track with four or five things on it and then two or three more musicians who backed them up. I mean all this network of stuff, and I'm thinking to myself, in my inexperience, then I said, "This is going to suck. It's going to be the worst mess." It was unbelievably great. I mean the conductor was good. But I mean that was my entrée into doing that.

MR: Contracting.

BA: And I did quite a few of those things. We did a couple of Broadway show things and a lot of things for Ray which was fun. I played in those you know. But over the period of years, when Disney stopped doing all their mega-musical things, it's too bad. I mean Walt's idea was a lot of live music but I think, and this is very basic, I think Disney discovered that since the entire continent of South America is going to empty on Orlando every year, they've got people coming from Brazil and Argentina. I mean you've got the

they didn't need all this entertainment. And it's too bad. And I saw it from a business perspective. I saw it happening because when Disney opened, this was October 1, 1971, they had an autonomous entertainment division, with a vice president, you know, a board, I mean boy we could do anything and get anything. And I saw over a period of about two years the entertainment division completely absorbed by operations. It just disappeared.

MR: The bean counters.

BA: And you know the 20-piece band went down to 12, which now, and it's a good bunch of guys. I couldn't do it. It'd kill me you know. But I mean it's oh, a lot of choreography and no reeds just all high trumpets and a lot of loud you know — and — but that's all they have in the Magic Kingdom. Now thank God for the World Showcase in EPCOT because they have a lot of international entertainment there, which they have to have. But I mean there were so many musicians in the Magic Kingdom alone. Little bands on the street corner if you're waiting in line there's somebody to entertain you.

MR: Well I've enjoyed talking to you today. It's been great fun.

BA: I hope I haven't gone too far.

MR: No, that's why I'm here, to get your story.

BA: Yeah. I've been really lucky to live, I'll be 81 next November and I just, for the little music schooling that I had I ended up in some pretty high profile places. And I love the guys I've met and played with, gee whiz you know. Louie Bellson was from my hometown. I got to do some things with Louie, played with Louie, and Buddy DeFranco would come in town and work with us because he knew Louie. And it's been a good ride.

MR: All right. Thanks for your time today.

BA: I hope I've given you something.

MR: You have indeed. Okay. Over and out.